Contract-Sanity Checklist

Before you sign anything, check the ten things that quietly hurt the most.

CONTRACT / AGREEMENT NAME _____

DATE REVIEWED _____

THE TEN CHECKS

- ☐ I can say in one sentence who owes whom what
  Parties, deliverable, price. If you can't, it's not ready to sign.
- ☐ All the numbers are written down, not just discussed
  Rate, total, deposit method, invoice timing. Words, not screenshots.
- ☐ I know exactly when I get paid — and it has a date
  "On approval" is a fog. "Within 30 days of invoice" is a date.
- ☐ Scope is specific enough to defend
  Rewards, revisions, and out-of-scope work all named. Vague scope is free work.
- ☐ Who owns the work when it's done? I understand it
  Copyright, license, credit. Common snag for writers and creators.
- ☐ Nothing here lets payment be cancelled after I've delivered
  Kill-fee and refund clauses — read them twice, slowly.
- ☐ If either side can walk away, I know what happens then
  Termination terms: notice period, final payment, returned files.
- ☐ No promises I can't keep (non-compete, exclusivity, deadlines)
  Exclusivity is easy to nod at and hard to live with.
- ☐ Disputes: where and how would they actually be resolved?
  Governing law and venue. Boring until the day it isn't.
- ☐ I re-read the whole thing once, and nothing surprised me
  Fresh-eyes pass. Surprises are questions, not dealbreakers.

OPEN QUESTIONS FOR THE OTHER SIDE

DECISION & DATE (SIGN, ASK QUESTIONS FIRST, OR WALK)

For serious money or confusing terms, a short consult with a licensed professional is worth it.